JURY BUNDLE

IN THE CROWN COURT AT ASHCOMBE · Case No: T20267041

REX *v* **SAMANTHA MORGAN** · Count 1: Murder

JUROR No. 7

NOT TO BE REMOVED FROM THE COURT BUILDING

AGREED FACTS

Admitted under section 10 of the Criminal Justice Act 1967. You must treat these facts as proved.

1. Graham Hale, 64, a retired engineer, lived at 16 Orchard Close, Ashcombe, with his wife Carol. The defendant, Samantha Morgan, 31, lived next door with her partner Ryan Mercer and her dog, Pepper. She has no previous convictions and no history of mental illness.
2. In 2024 the Hales complained to the council about the Morgans' hedge and extension. On 21 August 2025 the defendant texted a friend: *"I swear I could kill that man."*
3. On 2 March 2026, during a flare of her Crohn's disease, a hospital consultant prescribed **prednisolone 60 mg a day** (Exhibit FG/1). She took it exactly as prescribed.
4. On 9 March Pepper was sick after a walk. A vet found no sign of poisoning. Mr Hale never poisoned, or tried to poison, Pepper.
5. Between 10 and 12 March Mr Mercer repeatedly urged the defendant to call her GP, and rang NHS 111 himself. On 11 March her sister, Grace, found her talking very fast, saying she had slept two hours in three days and that Mr Hale was poisoning Pepper.
6. At 23:52 on 13 March the defendant searched online: *"is it legal to protect your dog from a neighbour"*.
7. On 14 March Mr Mercer left for work at 06:30. At 07:34 he texted: *"How you feeling this morning? Ring the GP when they open. Love you x"*
8. At 07:41 the defendant took a kitchen knife, knocked at No. 16, and stabbed Mr Hale four times when he opened the door. Police found her sitting calmly on her garden wall. Mr Hale died at 08:30.
9. The defendant accepts that she killed Mr Hale and intended to kill him or cause him really serious harm. She had taken no alcohol or other drugs.

S. Harcourt
Simon Harcourt KC, for the Prosecution

Kate Adeyemi
Kate Adeyemi KC, for the Defendant

From your lecturer: you are Juror 7. You have sat through a two-week trial. Everyone agrees Sam killed Mr Hale. Is it murder or manslaughter by diminished responsibility? Read these 6 pages in order (about 15 minutes), answer the **route to verdict** on page 6, then post your verdict and your best reason on the Padlet. Then talk to someone who voted the other way!

Photocopy of a page you kept from the Gazette, March 2026. You read this before you knew you would be a juror.

ORCHARD CLOSE

‘She just sat on the wall and waited’

Retired engineer stabbed on his own doorstep in quiet cul-de-sac

BY HELEN MARSH · CRIME REPORTER



Police officers guard a cordon in Orchard Close, Ashcombe, on Saturday, where a forensic tent was put up outside the home of Graham Hale. ***Picture: Gazette***



Graham Hale**, pictured on his allotment last summer.* ***Picture: family handout

“She was completely calm. She said good morning to me.”

SATURDAY MORNING. Residents said they heard a woman screaming shortly before 7.45am. Two police cars and an ambulance arrived within minutes. The close was sealed off until late on Sunday.

A woman of 31 has been charged with murder after a retired engineer was stabbed on the doorstep of his home in Orchard Close, Ashcombe, on Saturday morning.

Graham Hale, 64, was taken to Ashcombe General Hospital but died less than an hour later. His wife, Carol, 61, was in the house at the time.

Samantha Morgan, of Orchard Close, appeared before Ashcombe magistrates yesterday and was remanded in custody. She spoke only to confirm her name and address.

Neighbours described a long-running dispute between the two households over a hedge and a planning application. “There was bad blood, everyone knew that,” said one resident, who asked not to be named. “But it was the usual cul-de-sac stuff. Nobody expected this.”

Another neighbour, Dev Lal, 47, said he saw Ms Morgan sitting on a garden wall with “blood on her sleeves” when police arrived. “She was completely calm. She said good morning to me. That's what I can't get out of my head.”

A colleague of Ms Morgan's, who did not want to be identified, said she had been “not herself” in the fortnight before. “She was talking a mile a minute and saying she didn't need sleep. We thought she was just having a good week.”

Mr Hale was a former chairman of the Ashcombe Allotment Society and a volunteer at the town's food bank. His family said: “Graham was a gentle man who loved his garden, his grandchildren and his community. We cannot understand why this has happened.”

Wessex Police said they were not looking for anyone else in connection with the death.

► **Continued on page 6**

IN BRIEF

Bypass work to begin in May

Work on the long-awaited Ashcomb eastern bypass will begin on May 11 the county council has confirmed Drivers are warned to expect overnight clos ures on the A3612 for up to nine weeks.

Food bank appeal after record winter

Ashcombe Food Bank handed out 4,200 par cels between November and February, it busiest winter ever. Tinned fruit, UHT mill and toiletries are most needed. Donations ca be left at St Aldhelm's church hall.

Rovers edge derby

A late header from captain Liam Pocock gav Ashcombe Rovers a 2-1 win over Wellsbur Town on Saturday, lifting them to fourth i the Western League.

HENDRY'S
CARPETS & FLOORING
SPRING SALE
UP TO 40% OFF
Unit 4, Mill Lane Trading Estate
Free fitting on orders over £500



Floral tributes left at the entrance to Orchard Close yesterday. ***Picture: Gazette***

‘A pillar of this town’

Tributes have been paid to Graham Hale b friends at the Ashcombe Allotment Society an the food bank, where he volunteered ever Thursday. “He'd give you the shirt off hi back, and then some runner beans,” one frien wrote.



Allotment plots ‘could be lost’ to housing plan

BY TOM ELLERY-BANKS

ardeners at the Ashcombe allotments on Weir Road

ASHCOMBE MOTORS
Servicing · Tyres · Repairs

CLASSIFIED

FOR SALE. Oak dining table, 6 chairs, good cond. £120 ono Buyer collects. 07700 900 512.

WANTED. Old fishing tackle, reels, flies. Cash paid. Ring Derek 01632 960 771.

SITUATIONS VACANT. Part-time cleaner, Tues & Thurs am, S Aldhelm's Primary. Apply to school office.

LOST. Grey tabby cat, answers to Mungo, Weir Road area

WESSEX POLICE

Criminal Investigation Department · Major Crime Team (West)

RECORD OF INTERVIEW

Form MG15 · Summary/transcript of recorded interview

Person interviewed	**MORGAN, Samantha** (DOB 11/07/1994)	**URN**	52WP0314126
Place of interview	Ashcombe Custody Suite, Interview Room 3	**Date**	15/03/2026
Time commenced	14:05	**Time concluded**	14:46
Interviewing officer(s)	DC 4471 Rachel OWUSU · DS 2210 Ian PRYCE		
Other persons present	Mr Tarun KAUR, solicitor (Kaur & Webb LLP) · Ms Linda GRANT, appropriate adult (Ashcombe Appropriate Adult Scheme)		
Recording reference	DIR/WP/26/03/1147	**Offence**	Murder of Graham HALE

Caution given at 14:06 and understood: *"You do not have to say anything. But it may harm your defence if you do not mention when questioned something which you later rely on in court. Anything you do say may be given in evidence."* Assessed as fit to be interviewed, with an appropriate adult, by the custody nurse at 12:30 (the detainee was assessed as unfit on 14/03/2026).

Counter	Speaker	Transcript (extract; officer's introductions and legal rights omitted)
02:10	DC OWUSU	Sam, tell me in your own words why you went to Mr Hale's house yesterday morning.
02:18	MORGAN	Because he was killing Pepper. Slowly. He'd been doing it for about a week.
02:31	DC OWUSU	How did you know that?
02:33	MORGAN	I saw him. Not the actual — I saw the pattern. He went out to the hedge at the same time every evening. Ten past six. Then Pepper was sick. You don't need to see someone pull a trigger to know they've shot you.
03:02	DC OWUSU	The vet said Pepper hadn't been poisoned.
03:20	DS PRYCE	Is this about the hedge? The planning objection?
03:24	MORGAN	(laughs) No. God, no. That's — no. This is completely different. This was about protecting something that can't protect itself.
04:41	DS PRYCE	Ryan says he asked you to ring the doctor. Several times. Why didn't you?
04:47	MORGAN	Because I'm not ill. Ryan thinks the tablets have done something to me. They haven't. I've never been clearer in my life. I could see everything.
06:12	DS PRYCE	When you took the knife from the kitchen, what did you mean to do with it?
06:24	MORGAN	The only way that works.
07:50	DC OWUSU	Did you know that what you were doing was against the law?
07:55	MORGAN	I knew you'd come. I knew I'd be here. I looked it up, actually, what you're allowed to do. It didn't matter. Some things are more important than the law.
08:30	DC OWUSU	How do you feel about Mr Hale now?
08:36	MORGAN	Relieved. Pepper's safe. (pause) Is Carol all right? I didn't want Carol to see.

Transcribed by
J. Whitcombe · Civilian investigator 7731

Checked by (officer)
R. Owusu DC 4471

Date
18/03/2026

Ashcombe General Hospital
Department of Gastroenterology

Infirmary Road, Ashcombe AS3 7HG
IBD advice line: 01632 960 204

EXHIBIT FG/1

Dear Dr Pryor, **Re: Ms Samantha MORGAN, DOB 11/07/1994** Clinic date: 02/03/2026

Samantha has a severe flare of Crohn's disease. I have started **prednisolone 60 mg once daily**, reducing by 5 mg a week. I explained that high-dose steroids can cause sleep problems and mood changes and, uncommonly, more serious effects including agitation, elation and, rarely, psychosis. I asked her to contact you or our advice line if she notices any change in her mood or sleep, and to share the patient leaflet with her partner. She must not stop the tablets suddenly.

Yours sincerely, *Fiona Galbraith* **Dr Fiona Galbraith** MD FRCP, Consultant Gastroenterologist

WESSEX POLICE
Digital Forensic Unit

DEVICE EXTRACTION REPORT

Defendant's iPhone · selected items

EXHIBIT DF/3

Date / time	From → To	Content
21/08/2025 22:14	Sam → Jess W	Hale was out measuring the hedge again with a tape. I swear I could kill that man.
11/03/2026 03:12	Notes app	H at hedge 18:10 EVERY day. Pepper sick 9th. Vet = allotment society!! He thinks I don't see. I SEE EVERYTHING NOW.
12/03/2026 18:40	Sam → Ryan	stop telling me to ring the GP. I'm not ill. I'm AWAKE. for the first time in my life
12/03/2026 18:45	Ryan → Sam	I love you. I'm worried. The leaflet says to ring them if your mood changes. Please just ring them x
13/03/2026 23:52	Safari search	is it legal to protect your dog from a neighbour
14/03/2026 07:34	Ryan → Sam	How you feeling this morning? Ring the GP when they open. Love you x *(read 07:35, no reply)*

Ashcombe Forensic Psychiatry
Independent forensic and medico-legal psychiatry

2 Quay Street, Ashcombe AS1 5QS
01632 960 377
Registered in England No. 09114872

Mr Tarun Kaur
Kaur & Webb LLP, Solicitors
31 Bridge Street, Ashcombe AS1 3BE

14 July 2026
Our ref: PN/2026/118

Dear Mr Kaur,

Re: R v Samantha MORGAN — summary of psychiatric opinion

Diagnosis. On 14 March Ms Morgan had a **corticosteroid-induced psychotic disorder with manic features**, a recognised medical condition. Symptoms began within 48 hours of starting 60 mg of prednisolone and resolved as the dose came down. At this dose, about 1 in 20 patients have a serious psychiatric reaction.

The earlier grievance. Delusions take their content from existing worries. The hedge dispute supplied the *target*; the drug supplied the certainty, the urgency and the loss of judgement. Her late-night search shows she believed she was *protecting her dog*.

Opinion. Her ability to form a rational judgement was **substantially impaired**, and the condition **provides an explanation** for the killing. But for the prednisolone, I do not believe she would have killed Mr Hale. Now well, she told me: "My hand did it. But it doesn't feel like it was *me*."

Yours sincerely, *Priya Natarajan*
Dr Priya Natarajan MBBS MRCPsych
Consultant Forensic Psychiatrist (GMC 6104477). I confirm that I understand my duty to the court, and that this opinion is my own and within my expertise.

Ellery Medico-Legal
Consultant forensic psychiatry for the courts

Harbour Chambers, 9 Wharf Lane
Marlford MF2 8HQ
01632 960 552

Ms Jane Whitfield, Senior Crown Prosecutor
Crown Prosecution Service, Wessex Area
Ashcombe Office, Crown Buildings

11 August 2026
Our ref: ME/2026/0412

Dear Ms Whitfield,

Re: R v Samantha MORGAN — summary of psychiatric opinion

Diagnosis. I agree she had a steroid-induced psychosis on 14 March.

Where I differ. Motive came first: she wrote that she "could kill that man" seven months before the drug. **She was organised:** she chose a knife, waited, knocked, and harmed no one else. **She knew it was illegal:** she researched the law the night before and told police "some things are more important than the law". **She refused help:** she was warned in writing and urged by her partner and sister for three days.

Opinion. Her judgement was affected but not **substantially** impaired. The drug released a wish that was already there; it is not a significant explanation for the killing.

Yours sincerely, *Martin Ellery*
Dr Martin Ellery MB ChB FRCPsych
Consultant Forensic Psychiatrist (GMC 4021996). I confirm that I understand my duty to the court, and that this opinion is my own and within my expertise.

IN THE CROWN COURT AT ASHCOMBE
The Law Courts, Market Street, Ashcombe AS1 2LC

Case No: T20267041

REX

— v —

SAMANTHA MORGAN

DIRECTIONS OF LAW AND ROUTE TO VERDICT

1. **Evidence only.** Decide the case only on the evidence in this bundle. Ignore anything you read in the press at the time of the arrest. Do not let sympathy for anyone decide your verdict.
2. **What is admitted.** The defendant admits killing Mr Hale with intent. That would be murder unless she proves **diminished responsibility** (Homicide Act 1957, s.2). She must show it is more likely than not; she does not have to make you sure.
3. **"Substantially"** means important or weighty: more than trivial, but not total. **"Provides an explanation"** means a significant contributory factor. It need not be the only cause; she may also have had other reasons, such as a pre-existing dislike of Mr Hale.
4. **Medication.** She took the prednisolone as prescribed. This is not voluntary intoxication with alcohol or illegal drugs. A condition caused by prescribed medication can be a recognised medical condition.
5. **Experts.** You are not bound to accept either psychiatrist. Weigh their reasons with all the other evidence. The final questions are for you.

ROUTE TO VERDICT — answer in order. Questions 2–4: has the defendant proved it is more likely than not?

Q1	Are you sure the defendant unlawfully killed Mr Hale, intending to kill him or cause him really serious harm? *(Admitted.)* If NO: **not guilty**.	**YES** ☐ **NO** ☐
Q2	Was she suffering from an **abnormality of mental functioning** arising from a **recognised medical condition**? If NO: **guilty of murder**.	**YES** ☐ **NO** ☐
Q3	Did it **substantially impair** her ability to understand her conduct, form a rational judgement, or exercise self-control? If NO: **guilty of murder**.	**YES** ☐ **NO** ☐
Q4	Does it **provide an explanation** for the killing, being a **significant contributory factor** (not necessarily the only one)? If NO: **guilty of murder**. If YES: **not guilty of murder, guilty of manslaughter by diminished responsibility**.	**YES** ☐ **NO** ☐

VERDICT (Juror 7): Murder ☐ Manslaughter by diminished responsibility ☐

My strongest reason:

M. Hart

HHJ Morwenna Hart KC